

School Committee Meeting Notes - March 22, 2021

Mayor calls meeting to order - 6:06 PM

Roll Call - 7-0 - Salute the Flag

Mayor - Motion to move into Executive Session, to discuss superintendent employment

Motion to move into Executive Session by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Ruseau

Roll Call -7-0

Mayor - move into executive session - 6:11 PM

Mayor - meeting resumes - 6:37 PM - Please be advised that all dialogue must be respectful. I will not tolerate anything less after last week's meeting. Any insulting comments or personal attacks will result in no longer being allowed to speak for the remainder of the meeting!

Member McLaughlin - Additionally, Robert's Rules must be followed...anyone who speaks to committee, speaks through the chair

Mayor - And, everyone must provide name and address for the record. Thank you!

Mayor - Approval of March 8th Regular Meeting Minutes

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin , seconded by Member Van der Kloot - 7-0 - minutes approved

Mayor - Approval of bills, transfer of funds

Motion to approve by Member Van der Kloot, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call - 7-0 - bills approved

Mayor - Report of Secretary

McLaughlin - None

Member Kreatz - Mar 3rd - Building & Grounds Minutes - roll call wasn't taken - motion to approve these minutes, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call - 7-0 - Minutes are approved

Member Van der Kloot - Mar 10th - curriculum subcommittee - can we take this out of order, later in the meeting?

Member Ruseau - motion to table, seconded by member Graham

Roll Call - 7-0 - tabled

Member Mustone - Personnel & Budget Subcommittee - shared dates for upcoming budget meetings - went through dates and process for budget season - haven't set exact time frames yet

Mr. Murphy - As you will see from this slide, we will discuss topics under umbrellas - incorporate a number of departments - generally night meetings 5:30 - 6 PM start time - for public participation

Member McLaughlin - worthwhile to attend these budget meetings - would encourage public to attend

Member Graham - Last year, we asked department to include a wish list to improve outcomes

Mr. Murphy - Do you mean, not a part of the Superintendent's budget?

Member Graham - Yes. I can send you the notes from last year

Mr. Murphy - thank you

Member McLaughlin - thank you for the flow chart that you are revising for our next meeting

Member Ruseau - we did have a motion last year for this list to be added to each budget presentation?

Supt - we will use similar format from last year

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Mustone

Roll Call - 7-0 - Minutes are approved

Member McLaughlin - Special Education/Behavioral Health Subcommittee Notes - BH - Ms. Schulman discussed how her department has been addressing social emotional needs, as well as planning how to address those needs as students return to into school - people are feeling that SEL needs addressing before academics - Ms. Schulman discussed the Sandy Hook Promise Campaign Program ---Start with Hello - that will begin in April in the Middle Schools. Member McLaughlin - if I may, could parents/SC be invited to the Start with Hello presentations? Ms Schulman - we can work on that - real need for students to have some social interaction - group hike to Fells, one night of no homework - teaching classes outside on the field - Special Ed - continued discussion of building friendships within school communities - Suzannah Campbell has great google folder of materials - working with Paul Teixeira to have it translated - Hoping to expand Common Ground Program - Apr 27th - World Cafe will discuss Disability Awareness - for Diversity Week - Medford Recreation - adaptive programming being offered - update on inclusive playground at McGlynn Elementary School

Motion to accept minutes by Member Van der Kloot, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call - 7-0 - minutes passed

Member Van der Kloot - Motion to table curriculum subcommittee notes until next meeting - we need Dr. Chiesa presentation included, seconded by Member Graham

Roll Call 7-0 - minutes tabled until next meeting

Mayor - Public Participation

Member Graham - please read our policy on public participation - please post it to agenda - speak once & up to 3 minutes -

Member McLaughlin - clarification - one time - speak for 3 minutes without request ahead of time - the Wed before = (5) minutes presentation

***Member Van der Kloot - proper name/address - Lucci** (need person who sent email's name & address) - can't find the Columbus Renaming Advisory Committee information on website

Mr. Murphy - We will place it on the front page and recirculate to all families as well

Member Van der Kloot - Sharon Hayes - Ripley Rd - enrolled at fully remote for remainder of school year -should not be subjected to more changes - other people also feel same way

*****Get names/addresses from Paulette - Claire Flaherty -**

Member McLaughlin - We need to provide consistency to remote learners as well

Member Van der Kloot - will you address this Madam Superintendent?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Yes, in my remarks

Mayor - Superintendent Remarks & Updates

Dr. Edouard-Vincent -

As I mentioned in my Friday message, I have mentioned many times before, that we all have a duty to stand up against all forms of racism. Tonight I want to make clear that the Medford Public Schools stand with our Asian American & Pacific Islander communities. It is my hope that we can all come together and join Mayor Lungo-Koehn, the Board of Health, Medford's Human Rights Commission, the Medford Police Department and the schools as we participate in a Community Conversation entitled; "Racism is a Public Health Crisis: What Does This Mean and How Can the City Address This Crisis?" It will be held Wednesday, April 7th from 6-8 PM via Zoom. I applaud the Mayor, Chief Buckley, MaryAnn O'Connor, and our Diversity Director Neil Osborne for organizing this crucial conversation. We support #StopAsianHate, #SupportAAPI.

On March 10th, the School Committee held a Committee of the Whole with the goal of launching the Columbus Elementary School Renaming Advisory Committee, which will review all suggestions for a new name for the school. While the task of creating the Committee was accomplished, the means by which this was achieved was painful at times. Some conversations in the meeting involved angry and derogatory language. I know that the decision to change the name of the Columbus School is a controversial one and especially upsetting to many long-term residents of Medford. However, these unprofessional and unkind statements were not the positive displays of civic discourse we should be modeling for our children. I am hopeful that we can work together as one Medford, to be better to each other and to overcome our disagreements constructively and considerately.

Interested parties who may want to apply to serve on the Renaming Committee, can access an application on our website, the City's website, our Blog, facebook and twitter. For those who just want to suggest a new name, you may do so by completing that form on the website. All applications to serve on the Renaming Committee and any submissions for suggested new names must be forwarded to my office by 5:00pm on Friday, April 16, 2021.

I am pleased to announce that EdWeek, a school based, national publication, contacted our public relations office seeking input for their article entitled: Should Schools Test Students & Staff for

Covid-19? Medford truly has been a leader in this arena, allowing us to bring students back into our schools sooner than most of our surrounding districts. We could not have done this without the help and support of the City of Medford, Tufts University and the Broad Institute. Both our Assistant Superintendent David Murphy and our Director of Health Services Toni Wray were quoted in the article and photos were taken of elementary students being tested at the McGlynn Middle School. The Mustangs are certainly leading the charge to protect our students and staff, in order to bring our students back safely to in school learning.

I would like to take this opportunity to extend my sincere thanks to our students, staff, parents, and guardians and our school committee members for actively taking part in our Listening Sessions regarding school during Covid-19. When we planned these sessions, we did not yet know that the Massachusetts Education Commissioner would soon issue a statement mandating that districts abandon the hybrid learning model, therefore increasing in-person learning for students. This declaration has created some confusion for families.

Remote students *are* able to remain remote students but we know that there are a small number of families who wish to switch their students from remote to in-person. The deadline for making that switch is this Friday, March 26. We currently have 572 students who are fully remote at the elementary levels. As of this morning, we have received 61 requests from families that would like to participate in in-person. Please do not miss the deadline of this Friday to notify us of your decision if

I would like to provide some greater clarification. I reached out to the Commissioner of Education to ensure that Medford is properly following the guidance from DESE. This week our younger elementary, Kinder and Grade 1 hybrid students have already increased their in-school time to 4 days this week, -- Next week our 2nd and 3rd grade students will increase their in-school learning time to 4 days a week.

Please note that all elementary students switching from remote to in-person will return on Monday, April 5. Again all fully remote families that have selected to return to in-person instruction will return to school for 5 days of full instruction on Monday, April 5th. Next week, principals will reach out to families to notify them about their child's assignment for the week of April 5th. In order to mitigate the impact of additional students from our remote cohorts, we require extra planning time to make that happen as seamlessly as possible.

Event Reminders: the Emergency Preparedness Preparedness Zoom presentation will be held this Wednesday, March 24th from 6- 8 PM, CCSR has planned an April Fool's Run between April 1st and April 3rd, Next week, we will be posting an agenda for the Medford Public Schools Strategic Planning Roundtables, which will be held Monday, April 5th and Tuesday,

April 6th, & this Saturday, March 27th, the Citywide Elementary Alliance is hosting an Electronics Recycling Drive from 10 AM - 1 PM behind the McGlynn School.

Lastly, I would like to invite any college students and others in our community who might be interested in part time work, to join our After School Program team. We are hiring counselors right now. Happy Passover! Happy Easter! Happy Spring!

Member McLaughlin - thank you for update - exciting to see Medford highlighted in EdWeek

Member Ruseau - excellent update - a lot of topics - I'm looking for a commitment for no change of remote teachers for elementary - even if they have a really small class - remote feels like an after thought - so I'm hoping that's a no go

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I can't commit to that as yet - 61 families have opted to transition to in person, awaiting our final numbers on Friday - If numbers fluctuate too much - we have a lot of constraints with fitting students in classrooms - so I don't want to say this will never happen - we have to see the data before we can state who the teachers would be - we might need one teacher to return to the classroom and eliminate a remote teacher - our priority is always the students, but we are also working with DESE guidance - Having reached out directly to DESE - to give the best information possible - we will work hard for that not to happen - but I can't promise it - in the spirit of transparency - we are especially looking at K and 3rd Grade - in 2 schools - very close to max capacity - keeping safety, equity and consistency as our priorities - we aren't trying to disrupt or pull someone away - we don't want to deny any student the opportunity to attend in school

Member Ruseau - Sen Jehlen asked us to respond to the DESE guidance - what I see is: we are taking a moderately bad situation to make it good for some kids at the expense of other kids - to take away a teacher is unconscionable - its disturbing - take away something from one kid to give to another kid

Member Van der Kloot - although it doesn't sound fair - I hear you Madam Superintendent

Member Graham - I have received reports that individualized choice - remote families feel pressured not to be remote - parents shouldn't feel pressured - my position is that remote isn't making a change, their teacher shouldn't change - I appreciate the operational dilemma - I would urge an emergency meeting to expend funding for this not to happen

Dr. Edouard-Vincent -The Medford School district doesn't support pressuring or bullying of parents by parents

DESE's options are full in person, or remote - this is why I'm sharing the data - again we can work with the principals and have them follow up with the families, so they make sure they weren't coerced

Ms. Galusi - this is a very personal decision - we want the conversation to be held at the principal level, not in a black & white survey - we also know that we are more than $\frac{2}{3}$ of the way into the school year, rapport has been built with students - at this point, we are hopeful we can absorb it

Mr. Murphy - I'll provide a budget update later in meeting - I'm not anticipating a disproportionate surplus, but I think we are in the position - we would have the financial means to explore additional personnel - it would only be a matter of last resort - a teacher change in a remote setting would be only in an extreme situation - you'd have a bigger challenge of finding teachers at this time of the year rather than funding the positions

Vanessa Farsner - Barbara Lane - overwhelming situation with After School program - very upset - now we are in a situation that parents are using it as a playdate, rather than to provide actual childcare - maybe schools need to provide a mission statement - why MPS has a Before/After School program - we have people who are using it who don't need it

Mayor - we are actively trying to hire more counselors for the program so we can make more room for more families to be involved

Sharon Hays - 69 Ripley Rd - you read my email earlier - as a person who chose fully remote for the health of our children - my kids are struggling - and we talk about equity - I understand the competing needs you have - I have lost faith in this school system - especially with the equity question - I understand you are saying it would only be in a crisis situation - my faith is not very strong in the schools - this just makes it harder

Ms. Rocca - 3600 MVPkway - Why is the Medford Public Schools not asking for a waiver?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - waivers are being sparingly distributed - Medford provides testing multiple times per week, we are essentially not requiring a waiver at this time

Mayor - Covid update

Ms. Wray - City data - average positive rate is on the rise - across the state - Mar 18th 16.7 - 19.1 - 0.08% to 1.1% - (4) positive pools in schools - today MA begins, phase 4, step 1 opening - for schools we returned K and 1st to in person for 4 days - mandatory masks, classroom sanitation, 3 ft guidance, sanitation of hands - outdoors limited 25 people and 10 indoors - travel advisory

instead of travel order - if you as a family are traveling, please have a discussion with your school nurse for proper guidance - vaccines - in Phase 2 - K-12 educators - Pre register at Mass VAXfinder

Mr. Murphy - Budget Update -

Feb 22nd SC questions - we are closing FY21 - trying to provide as much information as possible during this budget time - (3) lanes heading to budget

Unique to FY 21 & 22 - significant external funding due to Covid related funding

FY22 challenges - Federal legislation that passed 2 weeks ago assists us a lot - but some of the potential cliff edges are a little further off - \$2.3M - we would have to detail by Mar 31st to state exactly what funding will be next 2 fiscal years - \$61.2M-Budget - operating budget approved by the SC and amended by C 70 monies when they became available =\$62M

Revolving accounts should be used for targeted purposes for services which would fluctuate with the services - this isn't to suggest we have million dollar surplus at all - non essential spending freeze - more due to a concern of deficit in revolving accounts - food service will decline more with more monies coming in - providing bridge funding for food service because participation just isn't there - at this point, we are about even with the totality of the revolving account deficits

Member Ruseau - I'm glad you are doing it all again - helpful to hear multiple times - is there a date when the number will be handed over?

Mayor - we have met with Tony Rizzotti - no guidance about federal stimulus yet - once we have that, we will give the schools the number

Mr. Murphy - we are hoping for surplating

Member Ruseau - considering unknowns, which we had last year, there are communities in MA - why don't we try this other approach, we develop the budget with what we think we need and send to Council, the Mayor sends her budget to council - and then we deal with what we get - all the depts have already done their budgets & what they need? Build a budget and not be worried with what we are going to get

Mr. Murphy - this year and next year will be a unique fiscal cycle - potential funding - we must be thoughtful - plus spread over a certain period of time - but not in the typical 2-3 months time that we are accustomed to - instead maybe intended to cover the next 2-3 years - with understanding we can develop priorities - I don't know what restrictions will be - it's conceivable to that the schools may say we don't want that money right now, but we'd rather spread over a period of time - identifying the needs not in the budget have overall helped us focus on work that still needs to be done - I don't think we are starting from scratch

Member Ruseau - we have cut our maintenance budget to almost nothing for example - we have been underfunded since the 1992 Ed Reform and Prop 2 ½ since 1986 - we should be talking about how we are making it work - I get tired of the conversation about how we are going to manage - but it's the kids who aren't going to manage

Member Graham - how much money is Medford getting?

Mayor - \$39.6 M - we will know more this week or next at the latest

Dr. Cushing -Summer Fun Camp and MVTHS Discovery Camp - we have begun working several weeks ago for summer events - we have to address both safety concerns and nursing needs - continuing testing for example - we are looking for means to provide academic and social emotional needs to students as well

Principal Fallon - MVTHS Discovery Camp - Middle school students over summer, rotate thru various programs

Member McLaughlin - how many kids?

Principal Fallon - 30-40 kids - open to all students in grades 6, 7, & 8

Member McLaughlin - All day?

Principal Fallon -No 8 AM - noon

Dr. Cushing - summer school - outdoors - re engage with their peers - help with the isolation students may feel - and looping in Ms. Wray

Member McLaughlin - Summer Fun?

Mayor - Inclusive

Dr. Cushing - infuse learning into the summer fun program

Member McLaughlin - I would respectfully move it to the Apr 12th meeting - families don't find out until very, very late - we should give it some serious consideration to Summer Fun Camp - an important community building program

Mayor - Athletics run summer fun?

Dr. Cushing - Community schools is under the Athletics umbrella

Motion by Member Van der Kloot to place Summer Fun Camp on Apr 12th agenda, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call- 7-0 - motion passes

Member Van der Kloot - programs we have had before, what about any remedial programs over summer?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - we are in the beginning stages of summer intervention planning - our goals are to use the summer to provide students with some opportunity to do academics and physical activity - to address needs for whole child - we are trying to figure - possibly trying to use more than one location - or offering more than one program

Dr. Cushing - Senior Class events -working with guidance from State -

Friday - May 28th - last day for Seniors

Thurs - May 27th - Prom - any space that can be rented outdoors - limit =150 - we are hoping that can be expanded - maybe host 2 proms if necessary - MVTHS will hold their annual banquet - May 6th or 13th

Annual Leadership & Scholarship Ceremonies

Wed - June 2nd - tentatively at Hormel - no capacity limit yet - but must be 6 ft apart - faculty, speakers, guests - guests must pre register - any participant who test positive - - speakers can remove masks for remarks - very limited tickets once we map out the seating - limited ceremony

Principal D'Alleva - Thanks to Member McLaughlin & her EdTalk for helping to bring forward the thoughts and concerns of our seniors - Great advisors in Ms. Riley Jones & Cheryl Giordano We are adapting this year, but we have a better handle on it this year than last year

Senior Leadership & Scholarship Nights

We were almost there last year for graduation - I'm hopeful that our earlier date will be able to work - Hormel will give an old school feel - there is cost renting space at Tufts - we will pass everything by BOH and Ms. Wray of course. Thanks everyone - especially Dr. Cushing for getting these events moved forward

Principal Fallon - For our senior vocational banquet - instead of off site - make it more intimate on campus - this year the MHS diploma will have a certificate on one side and diploma on the other - so happy that's coming back - I echo Mr. D'Alleva - everyone's making it feel special - and special thanks to Mr. Blauch and Ms. Fitzpatrick as well.

Member Van der Kloot - rain date for graduation?

Dr. Cushing - not as yet, but we will

Member McLaughlin - students produced that EdShow - I was concerned walking away from that presentation - this class has felt very lonely and forgotten - they had no Jr Prom and no senior class events - how are we addressing the SE needs for these seniors? Maybe do some signage to congratulate our seniors? - Mr. Blauch posting on facebook and instagram rather than just email - it's not an email generation - it's overwhelming -when can we meet as a community to uplift and celebrate these students? Don't need answer tonight

Mayor - I want to make sure you are partnering with Ms. Catallo, who met with some parents and I last week

Member McLaughlin - we need to know about these meetings

Mayor - it was a parent group

Principal D'Alleva - I know the PTO has been working on things as well. We may need to schedule a COW so that everyone is together or just a high school meeting?

Member McLaughlin - we need to merge -

Principal. D'Alleva - more on the high school level - I can work with the PTO

Principal Fallon - I agree - we will pull everyone together

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - we want the students to look for prom outfits,so we wanted to get the dates out there - so seniors know we want them to celebrate - but we have to keep safety as a top priority

Member McLaughlin - thank you all - so it would be great for people to know to get involved Maybe provide another update on the April 12th meeting?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - yes

Heather Rumenapp - 57 Harvard Ave - Thank you for helping seniors plan - is it possible to move the prom event to Hormel as kids haven't been able to get together all year - I'm on the PTO so we can't come up with events, until student officers come to us - we are doing the Sponsor a Senior - Ms. Catallo should touch base with PTO - we are running out of time

Mayor - we have been talking about it for a long time

Dr. Cushing - I'm happy to work with Principals D'Alleva and Principal Fallon to bring students together - I need to state this important reminder! Seniors and their parents/guardians must continue to follow the covid safety regulations so these events can, in fact be held. The events come close and fast together - Graduation is really about K-12 education, but it's the biggest opportunity for the student to cross the stage - Please we beg you to please do everything possible so we don't have to cancel events due to covid issues

Member Van der Kloot - I received another email - Matthew Page Lieberman Cushing St - senior who needs some mental health assistance - guidance hasn't been helpful

Principal D'Alleva - we've had advisory periods over the week - Stacey has provided resources to blast out to community - but we don't have a lot of participation

Member Van der Kloot - tell the student to contact Mr. D'Alleva directly?

Principal D'Alleva - yes

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - or Stacey

Mayor - Report of Solar panels - city lease space for purpose of solar panels on Andrews & parking spaces for panels/storage - reduce cost of electricity - enter into agreement with a 3rd party - panels owned by 3rd party

Motion to approve by Member Ruseau, seconded by Member Graham

Roll Call - 7-0 - motion is approved

Mayor - Old Business - No - Communications - No

Mayor - Student Representative questions - 4 PM at March 24th - to understand their participation as they serve on school committee

Motion for approval by Member Graham, seconded by Member Ruseau

Roll Call - 7-0 - motion passes

Mayor - Member Ruseau/Member Graham resolution - collect demographic data from those who apply for the before/after school program -

Member Ruseau - we don't know the starting point is

Motion to approve by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Ruseau

Roll Call - 7-0 - motion passes

Condolences to families of Helen Alpers, Robert Olson & Susan Bratton

Ms. Scott - 29 Blaisdell - to echo Vanessa for after school care - at a loss for what to do with after school programs - thank you to Paul & Jenny - voice my support for after school and all the initiatives for the students

Motion to adjourn by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Kreatz

Roll Call - 7-0 -

Mayor - meeting is adjourned - 9:07 PM